At Arutla, the first of the four demonstration schools to be ready, enrolment rose from 744 to 1,585 in a year, an increase of 113 per cent. Officials say 72 per cent of new admissions were students who had shifted from private schools. "All our initiatives are intended to strengthen parental confidence in government schools and encourage children, including those presently studying in private schools, to enrol in the public education system," says Dr Yogita Rana, secretary, education department.

The government's education sector reform effort is also being backed by a major infrastructure and institution-building push. For the YIIRS project, the ambition is accompanied by a substantial financial outlay of Rs 21,000 crore. Of the 119 assembly constituencies in Telangana, 105 are to have a YIIRS; some segments in Hyderabad will have to be excluded because of the lack of space for such large campuses. Each campus is designed to accommodate 2,560 students from Classes V to XII, with sports and co-curricular activities, digital and AI-enabled learning, specialised laboratories and a focus on skills and holistic development.

DELIVERY CHALLENGES

But like with much else in the country, the best of intentions come undone by poor delivery. It is no different in Telangana. Many schools had yet to receive their promised student kits by Dussehra, although distribution was scheduled to begin at the start of the academic year. At the Zilla Parishad High School in Madharam in Vikarabad district, for instance, students were found attending classes in civilian clothes and chappals.

Progress on setting up infrastructure for the YIIRSes has met with obstacles such as land clearances, which has slowed down construction. Administrative sanction has been granted for 87 schools, with proposals for the remaining 18 submitted to the government. Construction is underway at 71 locations, while contractors are mobilising at six. The others are at various stages of land clearance, detailed project report preparation and tendering, officials say. At least 10 schools are expected to begin operations in the 2027-28 academic year, with the remaining campuses to be opened in phases.

A BETTER START

What's been welcomed with great enthusiasm is the breakfast programme that is now an adjunct to the midday meals served in schools and aims to further improve children's nutrition, health and educational outcomes. At the Mandal Parishad Primary School in Rangapur, children begin trickling in by 8.15 am, an hour before classes begin. The village is 40 km from Kodangal, Reddy's assembly constituency. As S. Anusha, a farmer from the Scheduled Caste Madiga community, drops her daughters, Jashvika, in Class II, and Deeksha, in LKG, a Hare Krishna Mission (HKM) van carrying breakfast arrives. HKM is among the charitable organisations engaged by the government to implement the scheme, alongside the Akshaya Patra Foundation and the Manna Trust.

The breakfast comes from a centralised kitchen in Kodangal, one of 39 such kitchens being set up across Telangana at a cost of Rs 299.9 crore. Vans deliver the food in sealed steel containers, with quantities determined by app-based indents submitted by headmasters the previous day. The menu, certified by the Hyderabad-based National Institute of Nutrition, includes dosas, millet idlis, pooris and upma, served with chutney, sambar or vegetable kurma. Children in Classes I-V receive 100 ml of milk per serving, while those in Classes VI-XII get 150 ml, three times a week. On the remaining days, students from pre-primary to Class X are served ragi java, a millet-based drink rich in essential micronutrients. "Our children are now refusing to eat breakfast at home," says V. Venkatesh, a sanitation worker with the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation who lives in Rangapur.

Dr Rana explains Reddy's intent behind the scheme. "The morning breakfast programme was introduced with a simple belief: No child should enter a classroom hungry, and no child's learning should suffer for want of a nutritious meal." Under Reddy, the pilot was implemented in 2024 in Kodangal, which Rana says, showed "encouraging results, with attendance reportedly improving from around 75 to 90 per cent, alongside better punctuality, attentiveness and classroom participation".

Next on Reddy's agenda is a free bus service for children in state-run schools, with pick-up and drop-off at their doorsteps. It is the only bonus facility private schools offer, says the CM, but at an additional cost, placing a burden on poor families. Believing that the state's children deserve better, Reddy appears determined to completely "overhaul the system". ■

> **"ALL OUR INITIATIVES ARE INTENDED TO STRENGTHEN PARENTAL CONFIDENCE IN GOVERNMENT SCHOOLS AND ENCOURAGE CHILDREN TO ENROL IN THE PUBLIC EDUCATION SYSTEM"**
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> **DR YOGITA RANA,** Secretary, Education Department, Telangana